

SOC L1 → L2 Escalation Criteria & Workflow Report

A Practical Framework for Junior SOC Analysts to Triage & Escalate Alerts

SOC L1 → L2 Escalation Criteria & Workflow Report

Alert Triage · Severity Assessment · Escalation Decision Process

Escalation Criteria

- ! Critical Security Incident
- Malware or Ransomware Detected
- Suspicious Network Activity
- Unauthorized Access Attempt



Escalation Workflow



L2 Analyst Actions

- 🔍 Deep Dive Analysis
- 🛡️ Threat Containment
- ✅ Mitigation Steps
- 📄 Incident Reporting



Alert Volume



Incident Trends

17:15:209:36 Alert - Alert: J IP : 666.406 7 7:39 1486.00.496 : 17:15:209:36 Alert - Alert: 6A.888K; 5906.263:661, 1680.68.9.48 : 17:15:209:30 Alert - Alert: 46.8995K; 5900:05:084, 281.755.484 : 17:15:209:50 Alert - Alert: 46.8995K; 5900:05:084, 281.755.484 : 17:15:209:36 Alert - Alert: A IP : 133:406 1.783, 4680.06:348 : 17:15:209:70 Alert - Alert: 6A.1098K; 5900:06:154, 251.208.1.48 : 17:15:209:70 Alert - Alert: 6A.1098K; 5900:06:154, 251.208.1.48 :



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Introduction

This report outlines how a **Level 1 SOC Analyst (L1)** reviews alerts, validates severity, and determines when an incident requires escalation to a **Level 2 Analyst (L2)**.

The goal is to demonstrate structured decision-making skills used in real **SOC** environments where proper **escalation** prevents missed threats, reduces response time, and improves **incident handling** accuracy.

This project covers:

- **L1** responsibilities during initial alert triage
- **Severity** and impact **assessment** before **escalation**
- Criteria that qualify an incident for **L2** review
- Evidence collection and **reporting** requirements
- **Communication** format for **escalation** handoff

By documenting this workflow, the project reflects real-world **SOC** practices and builds practical readiness for a **Junior SOC Analyst (L1)** role.

Escalation Workflow

L1 Alert Handling to L2 Handoff

Triage → Assessment → Evidence → Escalation → Handoff

L1 Support



1. Receive, Triage & Investigate Alert
2. Attempt to Resolve Issue
3. Escalate Complex Problems

(Handles initial triage, low/medium alerts)

Escalate to L2



L2 Support



- ✓ Review Incident Details & Context
- ✓ Perform Advanced Troubleshooting
- ✓ Conduct in-Depth Analysis & Resolution

(Handles complex, high-risk & in-depth investigations)

- ✓ Provide Detailed Handoff Information
- ✓ Collaborate for Resolution

Escalation Workflow: L1 Alert
Handling to L2 Handoff



Workflow Steps

■ Alert Detected in SIEM / EDR / Email / SOC Queue

■ L1 Initial Triage

- Identify alert type (Phishing, Malware, Brute Force, etc.)
- Confirm asset/user involved
- Validate if the alert is real or false positive

■ Severity & Impact Assessment

- Low / Medium / High / Critical
- Business impact? Privileged user involved?

■ Evidence Collection

- Logs, screenshots, timestamps, IPs
- EDR/SIEM event details
- User confirmation if needed

■ Decision Point (Escalate or Not?)

IF:

- High/ Critical severity
- Privileged accounts targeted
- EDR/SIEM event details
- User confirmation if needed

IF NOT:

- False positive or low impact

→ **ESCALATE TO L2**

★ Final Step

■ L2 Handoff

- Share escalation summary
- Attach evidence
- Provide suggested next action

Triage → Assessment → Evidence → Escalation → Handoff

Escalation Decision Matrix (L1 → L2)

✓ Escalate to L2

- ✓ High/Critical Severity
- ✓ Privileged Account Involved
- ✓ Malware Detected
- ✓ Unable to Resolve at L1

— Remain at L1

- Low Severity / False Positive
- Issue Resolved Easily at L1

Escalation Thresholds -

Alert Category	L1 Review Requirements	Escalation Trigger (Escalate to L2 if...)	Action
Phishing / Email Threat	Check email headers, URLs, attachments, user confirmation	User clicked link, entered credentials, or malware delivered	🚩 Escalate
Suspicious Login / Brute Force	Check login pattern, IP, geolocation, user privilege level	Privileged account targeted, foreign IP, impossible travel	🚩 Escalate
Malware / EDR Alert	Check EDR status, quarantine logs, system health	Reappearing threat, persistence, lateral movement signs	🚩 Escalate
Unauthorized Access Attempt	Confirm asset ownership & business impact	Critical systems affected or configuration changes attempted	🚩 Escalate
Low-Risk / False Positive	Validate log event, confirm user activity	Benign behavior / internal / no indicators of compromise	❌ Don't escalate → Document & close
Policy Violation / User Mistake	Educate user, document & warn if needed	Repeated violations or impact to business operations	⚠️ Escalate based on recurrence

This decision matrix guides L1 analysts in determining when escalation is required to ensure timely investigation and response by L2 analysts.

Severity Risk Levels	
Severity	Risk Levels
Low	● Low
Medium	● Medium
High	● High
Critical	● Critical

Escalation Priority: Normal / High / Critical

L1 Pre-Escalation Checklist

Before escalating an alert to L2, the L1 analyst must complete the following checks to ensure the necessary information, evidence, and context is provided for a smooth handoff.

L1 Pre-Escalation Checklist

- ✓ Confirm alert type and category (Phishing, Malware, Brute Force, Unauthorized Access, etc.)
- ✓ Validate severity and business impact (Low/Medium/High/Critical)
- ✓ Identify affected user, asset, or system (Hostname, Username, IP)
- ✓ Collect initial evidence (logs, screenshots, timestamps, IOC details, user confirmation)
- ✓ Attempt allowed L1-level containment actions if appropriate (per SOC policy)
- ✓ Rule out common false positives or expected behavior
- ✓ Prepare a brief summary of actions taken so far
- ✓ Determine escalation justification (why L2 review is required)

If any of the following conditions are met, escalation is required:

- High or critical severity classification
- Privileged account or administrator access affected
- Evidence of compromise, lateral movement, or persistence
- Malware detected but not fully contained or removed
- Impact to business operations or critical services

⚠ When in doubt — escalate or not ?

If the analyst is unsure, lacks clarity, or suspects deeper investigation is needed, the safest action is to escalate to L2 for review.

This checklist ensures consistency across analysts and prevents incomplete or unclear escalation requests.

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⚠ When in doubt — escalate.

If the analyst is unsure, lacks clarity, or **suspects** a deeper investigation is needed, the safest action is to **escalate to L2 for review**.

Sample Alerts & Escalation Decisions (L1 Analyst Perspective)

1. Escalation Logic Summary:
2. Confirm → Investigate → Decide
3. Privilege, persistence, or compromise = ESCALATE
4. Low severity / no impact = Handle at L1
5. If uncertain → Escalate for validation (L2 review)

Sample Alerts & Escalation Decisions (L1 Perspective)

Sample Alert	Escalation Decision	Escalate to L2
 Suspicious email identified as legitimate marketing material	✓	Handle at L1
 Internal account locked out after several incorrect password attempts	✓	Handle at L1
 Known malware detected & quarantined on one isolated workstation	✓	⚠ Escalate to L2
 Verified phishing email sent to privileged account user		⚠ Escalate to L2
 SSH brute force attack from foreign IP on web server		⚠ Escalate to L2
 Remote code execution attempt via PowerShell by an unknown user		⚠ Escalate to L2
 Persistence detected via scheduled task on critical server		⚠ Escalate to L2

Incident Escalation Report (L1 → L2 Handoff Template)

Incident Escalation Report (L1 to L2 Analyst Handoff)

Incident Information

- Alert ID: _____
- Alert Type: (Phishing / Malware / Brute Force / Unauthorized Access / Other) _____
- Severity Level: Low / Medium / High / Critical _____
- Date & Time Detected: _____
- Source: SIEM / EDR / Firewall / Email / User Report _____

Affected User / Asset

- Username: _____
- Hostname / Endpoint: _____
- IP Address: _____
- Business Impact Level: Low / Medium / High _____

L1 Investigation Summary

- What triggered the alert:

- Actions taken by L1:

- Threat indicators / IOCs observed (if any):

- Containment attempts performed:

Reason for Escalation to L2

(Choose one or more)

- ☐ High/Critical severity
- ☐ Privileged account affected
- ☐ Evidence of compromise or persistence
- ☐ Malware not contained / reappears
- ☐ Business/operational impact detected
- ☐ Requires advanced investigation

Evidence Attached

- ☐ SIEM screenshots
- ☐ EDR/Logs timeline
- ☐ User confirmation notes
- ☐ IOC/Indicators list
- ☐ System or network details

Requested Action from L2

- What support or investigation is needed?

Submitted By (L1 Analyst)

Name: _____

Date/Time: _____



**Incident
Escalation Report**
(L1 → L2 Handoff
Template)

Blue Team vibes-



Tools Used (L1 Analyst Perspective)

Category	Tools / Platforms	Purpose
 SIEM (Log Monitoring)	Splunk / Elastic (ELK)	Triage, event correlation, alert validation
 EDR / Endpoint Security	Microsoft Defender / CrowdStrike (general mention)	Malware detection, quarantine review
 Email Security	Phishing analysis tools, header inspection, sandboxing	Validate phishing & suspicious emails
 Network/Access Monitoring	Firewall logs, VPN access logs	Investigate suspicious login activity
 Ticketing & Reporting	ServiceNow / Jira (or generic SOC ticketing)	Document actions, escalate to L2
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You do not need actual licenses for these — listing “exposure to / learning on simulation environments” is acceptable for beginners.

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SOAR Automation Concept for Escalation-

SOAR Automation Concept (L1 → L2 Escalation)

Security Orchestration, Automation & Response (SOAR) can automate parts of the L1 workflow to speed up decision-making, reduce false positives, and ensure timely escalation to L2.

Automated Steps

- Auto-collect logs and basic evidence from SIEM/EDR
- Auto-check IP reputation, sandbox results, and IOC lists
- Auto-assign priority to High/Critical alerts with tags (e.g., PRIV-ALERT, MAL-PERSISTENCE)
- Auto-create escalation ticket if conditions match escalation criteria
- Notify L2 analysts via email/SOC ticketing tool

Decision Logic (Example)

IF Alert Severity = High/Critical

AND Privileged Account OR Persistence Detected

THEN → Auto-Escalate to L2 + Attach Evidence

Workflow Automation Example

ALERT → Enrichment (IP/IOC lookup) → Auto-Priority → Ticket Creation → Assign to L2

Tools that could support this (Concept Level)

- Splunk SOAR / Phantom
- Microsoft Defender Automated Response
- Cortex XSOAR
- ServiceNow + SIEM Automation Integration

Benefit

Automation reduces manual triage workload and helps L1 analysts focus on true security issues.



Conclusion

This project demonstrates my understanding of the SOC escalation workflow from an L1 analyst's perspective, including alert triage, severity assessment, evidence collection, and proper escalation to L2. It reflects key skills required in a Security Operations Center, particularly the ability to differentiate between low-impact and high-risk alerts, handle tickets responsibly, and escalate when necessary.

By documenting this process, I aim to showcase **practical readiness** for an L1 SOC Analyst role and a strong foundation for growing into advanced incident response responsibilities.

Thank you for reviewing this project.



Contact Information



mekeshavv21@gmail.com



[www.linkedin.com/in/
keshav-chauhan-cyber](https://www.linkedin.com/in/keshav-chauhan-cyber)